

IDU REST API

API Input Validation - Frequently Asked Questions

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Table of Contents

OVERVIEW3

What characters are accepted in name fields?3

What are some examples of supported and unsupported names?3

What are the restrictions on spaces, hyphens, and apostrophes in names?4

How should customers submit address fields?5

Do you offer a service for resolving UK addresses?6

How does the API handle Unicode characters?6

How does the API return validation errors?6

Overview

Customers should use the Open API Spec and Developer Portal as the definitive reference for request schemas, field requirements, validation constraints, error codes, and implementation examples.

This FAQ should be treated as supporting explanatory guidance only. It should not be used as a substitute for the Open API Spec or Developer Portal when building, testing, or troubleshooting an integration.

Where examples are included, they are provided to aid understanding and should be checked against the current Open API Spec and Developer Portal before use.

What characters are accepted in name fields?

Name fields such as forename, middle name, and surname are validated using the name-character rules defined in the Open API Spec.

At a high level, supported values include Unicode letters, ASCII apostrophe, ASCII hyphen, and single spaces, subject to the detailed constraints in the Open API Spec and Developer Portal.

Input type	Validation rule
Allowed characters	Unicode letters, ASCII apostrophe, ASCII hyphen, and single space.
Rejected characters	Digits, symbols, punctuation such as comma, period, slash, colon, and semicolon.
Position restrictions	Names cannot begin or end with a hyphen, apostrophe, or space.
Consecutive character restrictions	Consecutive spaces, consecutive hyphens, and consecutive apostrophes are rejected.
Maximum length	forename, middlename, and surname are each limited to 64 characters.
Length basis	Maximum-length validation is based on characters rather than bytes.

What are some examples of supported and unsupported names?

Example	Result	Reason
O'Brien	Accepted	ASCII apostrophe is allowed.
Smith-Jones	Accepted	ASCII hyphen is allowed.
Anne-Marie	Accepted	ASCII hyphen is allowed.
Durand-Dupont	Accepted	ASCII hyphen is allowed.
García	Accepted	Accented letters are Unicode letters.
Björn	Accepted	Accented letters are Unicode letters.
John123	Rejected	Digits are not allowed in name fields.
Neil\$Smith	Rejected	Symbols are not allowed in name fields.
O"Connor	Rejected	Consecutive apostrophes are not allowed.
Joh--n	Rejected	Consecutive hyphens are not allowed.
-Smith	Rejected	Leading hyphen is not allowed.
Jones,	Rejected	Comma is not allowed.

What are the restrictions on spaces, hyphens, and apostrophes in names?

Character or pattern	Result	Customer guidance
Single space	Allowed	Use a single space only where required.
Consecutive spaces	Rejected	Do not submit names containing double spaces.
ASCII hyphen (-)	Allowed	Use the standard ASCII hyphen.
Consecutive hyphens (--)	Rejected	Do not submit double hyphens.
ASCII apostrophe (')	Allowed	Use the standard ASCII apostrophe.
Consecutive apostrophes (")	Rejected	Do not submit double apostrophes.
Leading or trailing hyphen, apostrophe, or space	Rejected	Ensure the name starts and ends with a Unicode letter.
Accented and non-English letters	Allowed	Unicode letter categories are accepted.
Unicode dashes, including en dash and em dash	Rejected	Use ASCII hyphen only.
Smart or curly apostrophes	Rejected	Use ASCII apostrophe only.

Example name	Allowed?	Reason
John Smith	Yes	Single space between names.
Mary-Jane Brown	Yes	Single ASCII hyphen (-) used correctly.
O'Connor	Yes	Single ASCII apostrophe (') used correctly.
José García	Yes	Accented Unicode letters are allowed.
John Smith	No	Contains consecutive spaces.
Mary--Jane	No	Contains consecutive hyphens.
O"Connor	No	Contains consecutive apostrophes.
-Smith	No	Starts with a hyphen.
Mary–Jane	No	Uses an en dash (–) instead of ASCII hyphen (-).
O'Connor	No	Uses a curly apostrophe (') instead of ASCII apostrophe (').

Simple rule: Names must begin and end with a letter, may contain single spaces, single ASCII hyphens (-), and single ASCII apostrophes ('), but no consecutive separators or typographic punctuation.

How should customers submit address fields?

Address input requirements vary by service and should be confirmed in the Open API Spec and Developer Portal.

At a high level, address values are submitted using the available address lines and postcode field, with customers responsible for mapping the relevant address components into the request.

Field	Requirement	Typical use	Maximum length
address1	Required for most services	House number and street name. Example: 204 JULIUS ROAD	64 characters
address2	Optional	Locality, district, or town. Example: BISHOPSTON	64 characters
address3	Optional	Town or city. Example: BRISTOL	64 characters
address4	Optional	County or region. Example: AVON	64 characters
address5	Optional	Additional information	64 characters
postcode	Required for most services	UK postcode. Example: BS7 8EU	8 characters

Any best practice guidance for submitting addresses?

Yes, wherever possible, customers should submit addresses in a clean, structured, and consistent format that mirrors the address as it would normally appear on a recognised UK address source.

Recommended best practice:

- **Use the postcode wherever available**, as this is one of the strongest fields for locating and matching a UK address.
- **Place the house number or building name and street name in address1**. For example: 204 JULIUS ROAD.
- Use the remaining address lines for locality, town/city, county, or additional delivery information, rather than combining the full address into one field.
- Avoid unnecessary punctuation, symbols, or formatting characters unless they are genuinely part of the address.
- **Remove leading, trailing, and duplicate spaces before submission.**
- Do not submit placeholder values such as UNKNOWN, N/A, TEST, or . where an address component is not known.
- Keep each field within the maximum length defined in the Open API Spec.
- Submit the most complete and accurate address available, rather than abbreviated or partially formatted values.
- Use Address Lookup where available to resolve or capture a recognised UK address before submitting it into downstream IDU REST API services.

Do you offer a service for resolving UK addresses?

Yes. We offer an Address Lookup service that can be used to determine whether a supplied address can be resolved to a recognised UK address within our dataset.

The service can also support address capture by allowing users to search for an address using partial information, such as a postcode, and then select the correct address from the returned results. This helps improve address accuracy and ensures that a correctly formatted address is used within downstream processes.

How does the API handle Unicode characters?

Unicode letters are accepted in name fields because the validation rule uses the Unicode letter property.

This includes accented Latin characters and other Unicode letter categories such as Cyrillic, Arabic, Hebrew, Greek, and CJK characters.

Unicode normalisation is not applied, characters are accepted as submitted.

Non-letter Unicode characters, including emoji, symbols, and extended punctuation, are rejected in name fields.

How does the API return validation errors?

When validation passes, customer-submitted values are processed as submitted unless otherwise stated in the Open API Spec or Developer Portal.

If validation fails, the API returns the relevant validation error described in the Open API Spec and Developer Portal.

The examples below are explanatory only and should be checked against the current API documentation.

Scenario	API behaviour	Returned message or note
Invalid character in a name field	Request rejected with HTTP 422 Unprocessable Entity.	The {field} contains invalid characters
Non-letter Unicode character in a name field	Request rejected with HTTP 422.	Submit only valid name-field characters.
Non-UTF-8 encoded input	Parsing error occurs at the HTTP layer before validation is reached.	Submit data as UTF-8 encoded JSON.
Valid Unicode letter in a name field	Accepted as submitted.	No Unicode normalisation is applied.

For More Information

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